A Married State

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‘A Married State’

Here is a detailed guide to Katherine Philips’ poem ‘A Married State’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Philips’ poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Philips’ poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Katherine Philips’ intention and message

‘A Married State’ overview

Katherine Philips expresses a bold opinion on the state of marriage from a female perspective in seventeenth century Britain. Her poem, ‘A Married State’, offers advice to all single women on why they should avoid marriage as it often limits rather than frees women.

‘A Married State’ breakdown

Lines 1–2

> **“A married state affords but little ease;**
> **The best of husbands are so hard to please:”**

Translation

Philips' intentions

- The poem's opening statement offers a harsh criticism on the trials of marriage
- Philips extends this criticism to all marriages, even the "best ones", and claims it is because husbands cannot be easily satisfied

Lines 3-4

> **"This in wives' careful faces you may spell,**
> **Though they dissemble their misfortunes well."**

Translation

- The poet says that you can see the ill-ease in the wives' faces:
  - They are "careful" to hide their troubles and "misfortunes"
  - They "dissemble" their faces, meaning they put on a happy face as a disguise

Philips' intentions

- Philips hints at the imbalance of power in seventeenth century marriages, and how this leads to deceit
- She alludes to females being forced into marriage, implying wives cannot express their negative feelings which, in turn, represses them:
  - If only people would look more closely, they would see that the wives are pretending

Lines 5-6

> **"A virgin state is crowned with much content,**
> **It's always happy as it's innocent:"**

Translation

- The narrator says that virginity is a happy ("content") state to be in as it is innocent

Philips' intentions

- Philips' reference to a crown suggests that, for women, staying single brings power and contentment
- By describing virginity as innocent, Philips implies marriage is the opposite:
  - Perhaps that the state, or experience, of marriage is corrupt

Lines 7-10

> **No pangs of childbirth to extort your tears,**
> **No children's cries for to offend your ears,**
> **Few worldly crosses to distract your prayers."**

Translation

- The narrator offers a list of reasons to stay single and childless:
  - There is less fear as there are no "blustering", bad-tempered husbands
  - There is no pain from childbirth, nor constantly crying children
  - The image of "worldly crosses" may refer to temptations that would take one away from spirituality or religion ("prayers")

Philips' intentions

- The poet's argument on the merits of staying single is made more persuasive with anaphora, "No"
- Philips' list of "tears" and "fears", offences, and distractions avoided by staying single uses emotive and religious imagery to strengthen her argument:
  - The suggestion is that the speaker has found out these things too late

Lines 11-12

> **"Thus are you freed from all the cares that do**
> **Attend on matrimony, and a husband too."**

Translation

- The poet says that staying single and childless means "you" (women) are free of all the worries that go along with marriage ("matrimony") and motherhood

Philips' intentions

- The confident voice of Philips' narrator presents a female speaker who uses logic and persuasive language to present a strong argument against marriage
- The poem subverts traditional and patriarchal ideas of marriage by suggesting a husband is an annoyance, or a burden, rather than a benefit

Lines 13-16

> **"Therefore, Madam, be advised by me:**
> **Turn, turn apostate to love's levity.**
> **Suppress wild nature if she dare rebel,**
> **There's no such thing as leading apes in hell."**

offers advice:
    - "Turn" away and renounce the shallowness ("levity") of love
    - Do not allow temptation, desire, or a "wild nature" to take control

- The poet references an old proverb about unmarried women, and says it is not true:
    - The proverb stated that unmarried women caused otherwise good men to stray from their marriages, like "apes in hell"

Philips' intentions

- Philips' poem is presented as advice to all unmarried women
- The strength of her tone is conveyed in the repetition of "turn", and emphasised in the word "apostate", which means to desert or abandon a cause
- Philips alludes to the idea of self control as necessary to avoid marriage
- She calls for abstinence and self-discipline, ending with a witty and defiant reference to traditional criticisms of single women

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes and, specifically, the "deeper meanings of the poem". Examiners advise you to spend more time thinking about, for example, the reason **why** Katherine Philips creates a calm and reasoned argument, rather than a free-flowing and emotional speaker.

To achieve a convincing analysis, mentioning rhythm and rhyme should develop into an exploration of **why** this has been used, and the reasons the poet wants to slow or increase pace. The word "why" has been used a lot in this paragraph. That's because analysis means asking yourself **why** a writer has created a certain effect.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. The poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam wants you to consider all three as "writer's methods". This is because a poet uses all three to create meaning or convey ideas. Consider things like the poet's choice of form and perspective, its rhythm, rhyme, and tone of voice, and imagery.

Examiners require you to focus on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. To do this, you can discuss how the poet's methods reveal their aim or purpose. That is why all the

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

The poem is presented in an ordered form through which to give her advice to all women. This allows her to present a rational speaker, one who has formed her strong and controversial opinions on marriage based on reason and logic.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's tight, sixteen line stanza presents a controlled and disciplined speaker who addresses an implicit, female listener, "Madam"	Philips subverts traditional attitudes that women are emotional and irrational by constructing a convincing voice with which to criticise seventeenth century social norms

Structure

In 'A Married State', Katherine Philips uses a sophisticated structure to present a scathing attack on traditional ideas of marriage.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic relationships	The poem is in strict iambic pentameter and made up of rhyming couplets throughout	Philips' speaker is authoritative and calm in order to present the benefits of avoiding marriage, and to empower unmarried women to remain so

Language

Katherine Philips uses sophisticated imagery to highlight contrasts between married life and unmarried life.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Romantic relationships	The poet uses alliteration to draw attention to key ideas, such as in "crowned with much content", and "Turn, turn apostate to love's levity", ending the	Philips avoids elaborate imagery as the poem is a rational argument but, at times, a passionate speaker alludes to classical images that contrast the bliss of staying single with the shallowness and

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed, personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations** and **events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Katherine Philips examines in her poem 'A Married State':

- Individual identity
- Romantic relationships

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners reward an answer that responds "sensitively and in considerable detail" to the way the writer achieves their effects. You are being asked to explore the poem beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes. For example, while knowing about seventeenth century attitudes to marriage, or Katherine Philips' own circumstances, will help you understand the debates she raises, your points must always be closely linked to the themes in the poem and relevant to the focus of the question, rather than simply listed as factual information.

Individual identity

- Katherine Philips is a highly respected and influential seventeenth century British poet and writer
- Philips' poetry is known for its sophisticated, classical styles:
  - Her poem 'A Married State', written in the late 1640s-1650s, adheres to traditional poetic techniques
- As much of her work examines the female experience, she is considered to be an early feminist writer
- The poem 'A Married State' can be considered a cautionary message
- The poem challenges typically idealised female roles, such as its suggestion that motherhood is best avoided:
  - Philips alludes to seventeenth century conditions for women, including painful and, often, fatal childbirth

Romantic relationships

- Katherine Philips' seventeenth century poem, 'A Married State', is a challenge to gender imbalances that, the poem argues, manifest in dysfunctional marriages

perceived as wild and dangerous; a myth, she says, that was designed to force them into marriage

- At the time, marriage amongst all but the lower classes could provide security and status; a financial contract that can improve social standing:
  - Often, a young girl was married to a much older man
- As women were not allowed any financial or personal independence, this led to power imbalances:
  - The poem alludes to the limited power of wives: they are fearful of abusive husbands and fake their happiness to avoid retribution
  - The controversial nature of Philips' poem is evident in the line "Turn, turn, apostate"
  - This suggests unmarried women are traitors for abandoning social norms

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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